Pine Valley Special Services District

Meeting Minutes - PENDING

Pine Valley Fire Station, 680 East Main Street, Conference Room

Wednesday, November 12, 2025

Board Members:	Mary Esther Putnam, Chairwoman Bob Dalley, Vice-Chairman Allen Cannon Emily Neilson Steve Shakespeare
PVSSD Assistants:	Rick Peetz, Clerk Teri Forbes, Treasurer Fire Chief, Robert Hardy
Guests:	Susie McArthur Reed McArthur Dan Forbes Duane Krohn Audrey Krohn John Robson Roland Finger David Finger Darlene Finger Tom Nielsen Frank Davie Brad Esposito Stephen Zellers

1. Welcome: Chair Mary Esther Putnam called the meeting to order at 7:15 PM and welcomed those present.

Chair Putnam read a written statement and thanked those who helped restore the storm drains and culverts and rebuild the roads that were washed out by the flood. She commented on the Government Records and Management Act ("GRAMA"), which is part of State Code. She noted that the Pine Valley Special Service District ("PVSSD") Board is all volunteer, with the exception of the Clerk and Treasurer, who are independent contractors. The terms of two board members will expire on December 31, 2025, which will leave two vacant positions. She offered to provide applications to citizens wishing to apply.

Bob Dalley pointed out that this past month, a GRAMA request was submitted that required over four hours to complete. The policies allow the PVSSD to assess the person requesting the cost, which is minimal at $25 per hour. Rick Peetz responded to the request.

2. Approval of October Meeting Minutes:

Allen Cannon moved to APPROVE the October Meeting Minutes. Emily Neilson seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

3. Update on Flooding and Mitigation Efforts – Mark Owens.

Mark Owens reported on the following:

- The seeding operation is underway and expected to be completed this month.
- The government shutdown has caused delays in permitting reviews, stream alteration, cultural resource studies, and archaeological studies. It was unknown whether the time lost would be added to the current contract, which is set to expire on March 27, 2026.
- Culverts were being installed and have been delayed to complete the needed asphalt repairs. Two culverts were to be installed to the west of the existing culvert, and they will be double to triple the size. The design is 60% complete and on schedule. Bid documents were expected to go out in early January.
- The riprap using local rock did not meet the suitability requirements and an alternative material was expected to be imported.

4. Webmaster Update – Robert Hardy.

Fire Chief, Robert Hardy, reported that Joseph Hunt has provided the requirements to be met to move the DNS to the new server. Permission was also needed to make the change.

Chief Hardy presented the ongoing 2026 budget and reported that the cost will be $7 per person for email service and $200 per year to maintain the Information Technology (“IT”). Rick stated that the budget line item was $2,000.

5. Fire Department Report – Robert Hardy.

Chief Hardy reported that the flooding on October 10 resulted in a significant number of equipment and volunteer hours.

Emily asked if any decisions had been made about the community using the Fire Station now that the Central Chapel is open. Chief Hardy explained that it is already established in the Policies and Procedures regarding use of the station. The station can be used by the community as long as it is community-

wide, scheduled through him, a member of the Fire Department is present, and hosting the event does have an associated cost to the department.

Bob asked how emergency services will be handled during the two-hour church service each Sunday in Central. Chief Hardy reported that he plans to remain in the valley during church services. There are several members of the department who do not attend church services who could respond as well.

6. Request for Approval to Extend the VEST Contract through 2026 – Teri Forbes.

Teri Forbes reported that she serves as the Fire Department Mental Health Liaison. For 2025, a grant in the amount of $16,000 was received from the State for mental health services. The grant funds were only available for one year, so 2026 will have to be self-funded. VEST has provided the services and has agreed to extend the contract with the same services for $8,012. It was noted that the services are available to Fire Department Members and their families. The various services, trainings, and debriefs performed this year were described. Chief Hardy explained that in January of 2024, the Legislature passed a House Bill requiring responder agencies to offer mental health resiliency to their personnel, including current, retired, and family members.

Bob Dalley moved to EXTEND the VEST contract through 2026. Allen Cannon seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

7. Clerk and Treasurer's Reports (October) – Rick Peetz and Teri Forbes.

Teri presented the Treasurer's Report and stated that she reconciled the accounts and verified that they are in order.

Rick presented the Clerk's Report and stated that Rick Holmes returned the check sent to him in the amount of $3,396. He included a nice letter declining the funds and expressing their appreciation. They asked that the funds be used to benefit the community. The decision was made to void the check.

Donations received during the fire via Venmo were in the process of being itemized. Rick would make the allocations internally and clarify at next month's meeting. Future issues would be avoided due to a specific Venmo account having been created since the fire.

Bob asked that the fund balance limitation be included in the Policies and Procedures and noted that there is $278,000 in cash in the various six PVSSD accounts. The roughly $86,000 from impact fees is used for capital

improvements, and the annual assessment is approximately $180,000. He suggested that a specific amount be set aside for capital improvements. There is currently a plan for the impact fees only. Rick expects to roll over from the various accounts, resulting in $131,500 at the end of the year. The intent is to allocate the funds for the purchase of a fire engine.

Bob Dalley moved to ask Emily to AMEND the Budget policy regarding the State's Fund Balance Limitation requirement. Allen Cannon seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

Bob Dalley moved to ACCEPT the Clerk and Treasurer's Report. Emily Neilson seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

8. 2026 Tentative Budget to be presented for Board Review – Rick Peetz.

Rick presented the 2026 Tentative Budget and adjustments to the 2025 budget. He reported that going forward, there will be Income of $173,600. Under Building Expenses, last year's budget was $13,200, with a proposed budget of $12,500 next year. The difference was higher electrical costs and an increase in Supplies and Materials to $500.

With regard to motor vehicles, they have exceeded the budget due to maintenance and repair costs. A budget of $25,000 was proposed to keep the trucks running. In 2025, he expects to spend $23,130 while the budget is $23,500.

The Travel and Training line item increased by the $8,012 needed to extend the VEST contract.

Under Communications and Radios, he moved what they expect to spend this year forward in amount $300 higher than last year. The line item for Food and Water decreased due to donations received this year. The SCBA budget decreased, and the EMS budget decreased by $1,000. Potential pay increases for the Clerk and Treasurer were to be considered at the next meeting.

A Grant Writing line item in the amount of $4,500 was described. Rob Nodine found a funding navigator who acts as a clearinghouse for grants. It is a subscription process, and the community is expected to see a return on the investment. Grant issues were discussed. Rob explained that the company provides assistance navigating the grant writing process. There was potential as part of the grant process to apply $1,500 toward the subscription cost. The

goal was to find additional grant opportunities. The board determined to proceed with the Grant Writing line item.

With regard to next year's capital expenses, Chief Hardy stated that next year they are asking that any surplus be earmarked for future apparatus purchases. The determination was made by the Board to put $5,000 in capital expenses for 2026. Equipment acquisition issues were discussed.

Rick expects to have $70,000 left over from this year's expenses that will put the budget at $131,500. In Impact Fees, there is currently $86,521. By the end of the year, he expects to have $115,000, which must be used on capital items.

9. PUBLIC HEARING: Amendments to the 2025 Capital Budget to three items proposed by Chief Hardy at last meeting, consisting of (1) a Zoll Monitor ($24,610.68); (2) a positive-pressure ventilation fan for Engine 141 ($6,434.60); and (3) a drone with thermal imaging ($17,000.00). Chair Opens the Public Hearing. Please note: Each speaker will be allotted a maximum of two minutes to speak.

Bob Dalley moved to CLOSE the public meeting. Emily Neilson seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

Bob Dalley moved to OPEN the public hearing on the 2025 Capital budget. Allen Cannon seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

Chief Hardy described the proposed items as follows:

- A Zoll Series X refurbished monitor that will replace an old Phillips monitor that has reached its service life at a cost of $24,600.
- Replacement of a positive pressure ventilation fan in Engine 141 at a cost of $6,430.60. The purchase was to be partially paid for by firefighters who donated their paychecks toward the purchase of a new fan that is more reliable.
- $17,000 for a drone with thermal imaging to enhance the department's search and rescue and wildland capabilities. Cheaper models are available, but cannot be purchased legally because they are manufactured in China. Models that are government-approved cost more.

Darlene Finger supported the purchase of the Zoll monitor but took issue with the price of the fan and the drone. She wanted to save money where possible. She introduced her son, David, who is a paramedic in California.

David Finger reported that his department uses the same Zoll monitor, but stated that there are issues with it, such as hospitals cutting the leads, which are expensive to replace. He took issue with the electric fan, which his department has stopped using. They instead use Milwaukee saws to cut roofs off, with the batteries being reasonably priced at $100. The batteries for the proposed fan cost $300 to $400 each, and two are needed. The chargers also tend to fail. David stated that their equipment uses ethanol-free gasoline that does not go bad. They also perform daily, weekly, and monthly maintenance. He questioned the need for the drone as well. His department has a handheld unit with thermal imaging for brush clearance, and he noted that drones cannot be used during fires. Other equipment options were discussed.

Tom Nielsen noted that gas-powered blowers cost about half as much and are more powerful because they use positive pressure ventilation. They use Honda engines, which are very reliable. He supported saving $3,000 and stated that the Fire Department also has a Kubota that goes a maximum of 35 MPH. He considered that to be sufficient in the Valley or on trails. The point was made that the County has a drone, but it is one hour away.

Brad Esposito serves as the Fire Department's Drone Pilot, and he has been licensed for 2 ½ years. He has used his personal drone on three or four calls and flies it regularly during training. In the event of a major event, Search and Rescue will use their drone; however, if there is a small fire or other event, the use of the drone can provide situational awareness. Brad noted that drones are becoming standard in many fire departments.

The cost difference between Chinese and US drones was discussed. Brad stated that he owns the drone that is currently used by the department, and he is liable when he flies it. He did not think that practice should continue. Thermal imaging is useful in the event of lost hikers and spot fires. David Finger commented that the County uses Civil Air Patrol and can locate people who are lost. He did not consider two or three incidents per year to warrant the purchase of a $17,000 drone.

Rick pointed out that $34,500 has been received in donations to the Fire Department. Last year's budget was $42,500 for equipment, and it is $81,000 this year. The difference is $39,000, which is close to the amount of the donations received.

Rob Nodine reported that there was an incident last year at night where a man got out of his car, fell, and could not get back in his car. It was cold, and he

became hypothermic. Search and Rescue was dispatched; however, with a drone, they could have located him sooner, and it would have been a great tool to have. He also noted that Pine Valley is some distance from help, especially for someone who is hurt.

Bob pointed out that 75% of the cost of the proposed equipment to be purchased will be paid for with donations.

Chief Hardy described another experience around the time of the Forsyth Fire when many were hypersensitive about fire flare-ups. There were times when it was difficult to tell if something was a fire. A crew was dispatched, but there was low visibility. A drone with thermal imaging could have determined whether there was an issue or not in a fraction of the time. He stated that the Fire Department consists of volunteers who sacrifice time with their families, and this type of equipment will be very helpful. He noted that so far this year, over 4,400 volunteer hours have been donated.

A question was raised as to why the Chief chose the battery-operated fan rather than gas. Chief Hardy stated that they do not run the engines every day like a full-time department, and it is difficult to maintain gas engines when they are only run once a month. The current fan is also old. The proposed fan uses the same batteries as the jaws of life, which provides additional capacity. The goal is to have less maintenance. He noted that firefighters donated their pay from the Forsyth toward the purchase as well.

Tom commented that for the same price, the department could purchase two gas fans that have proven themselves reliable and more powerful.

Susie McArthur asked if there was interest in multiple agencies pooling their money to purchase a drone. Steve stated that in such a case, each organization would want it in their department. There are also liability issues to consider. Steve stated that the proposed cost is minimal compared to other agencies. He considered the drone to be a luxury and recommended the gas fan be purchased rather than electric.

Emily remarked that while the Board should question costs, they should leave the decision on the type of equipment purchased to the Chief and his officers.

Dan Forbes recalled a previous incident where the drone could not be flown because Search and Rescue was on its way. He wondered if an agreement could be reached to use the drone until they are nearby. Chief Hardy stated that when the incident mentioned occurred, the department did not have a good relationship with Search and Rescue. That has since changed.

There were no further public comments.

10. Motion to Close the Public Hearing.

Bob Dalley moved to CLOSE the public hearing. Emily Neilson seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

11. Chair Reopens the Public Meeting.

Bob Dalley moved to OPEN the public meeting. Emily Neilson seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

Bob Dalley made a motion and it was seconded, to APPROVE the three 2025 budget adjustments discussed in the Closed Session with an additional condition that Chief Hardy reconsider the gas or electric fans, but that the board would support Chief Hardy's final decision. The motion was unanimously approved by the Board.

12. Annual Board Fraud Risk Assessment Form/Report – Bob Dalley and Allen Cannon.

Emily thanked Bob and Allen for reducing the risk from one year ago.

Bob Dalley moved to ACCEPT the Fraud Risk Report and file it with the State on or before December 31, 2025. Allen Cannon seconded the motion. The motion passed with the unanimous consent of the Board.

13. Conflict of Interest and Ethical Behavior Forms to be signed by Board Members – Bob Dalley.

Forms were to be filed before the end of January. The matter was to be added to the January agenda.

14. Quarterly Bank Reconciliations Report – Bob Dalley and Allen Cannon.

Bob reported that he and Allen, together with Treasurer, Teri Forbes and Clerk, Rick Peetz, reviewed the various SSD accounts bank statements and compared them against the book cash balances and the related reconciliations from July through September. Allen and Bob found no long-dated outstanding deposits or checks, and to the best of their knowledge and belief, the accounts looked appropriate. He noted that the quarterly review and oversight by

members of the board are part of the annual Fraud and Risk Assessment requirements.

15. Citizen Requests.

There were no citizen requests.

The meeting adjourned at 9:05 PM.

The next scheduled PVSSD meeting will be on Wednesday, December 10, 2025.